Needed: A Bold Vision



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As **SOMEONE KEEN TO SEE THE WORLD** of academe in India elevated to worthy heights I am often reminded of the lament—from the 1980s—of one of India's most distinguished academics and a former vice-chancellor of Allahabad University. His anguish stemmed from the fact that somewhere along the way independent India had been unable to steer our universities in the right direction. By way of illustration, I can provide many insightful instances but perhaps none would be as telling as that which has Srinivas Ramanujan at its centre and which transpired more than a hundred years ago.

As most of us know, Ramanujan's name had been struck off the rolls of Madras University after he failed to clear his English language examination. But by then he had already produced some profound work in mathematics and it was evident to many senior contemporaries that he was no ordinary student. Yet, Madras University had no hesitation in stripping him of his scholarship and disqualifying him as a student. Soon after that shameful episode, G.H. Hardy—that outstanding mathematician and humanist at Cambridge University—received a letter from Ramanujan. In no time he got Cambridge University to offer Ramanujan a handsome salary and a formal position. In addition, they awarded him their version of a proper doctoral degree, on the basis of the work he had produced in India. Remember, Ramanujan then had failed to clear the equivalent of the Grade 12 exam at Madras University. Did Cambridge care much about such formal niceties? Not when they understood that having Ramanujan in their midst would greatly enhance research at their institution.

Let us contrast that with the situation that prevails now, all these hundred and more years since Ramanujan's time in India. Had Ramanujan come to me at the University of Delhi when I served as its vice-chancellor (2010-15), I would not have been able to enrol him as a student at Delhi University nor would I have been allowed to award him a PhD degree. Of course, I would have hailed him as a mathematician with divine gifts, but the regulations—not of my choosing or making—imposed upon the university and others by weighty institutions that have charted the course of higher education in independent India would have prevented me from doing what Cambridge University could do for Ramanujan more than a hundred years earlier. To my mind, this more than aptly sums up what ails India's universities.

There are, of course, many other issues that have not helped our journey in the realm of higher education. However, if Indian universities wish to rise to great heights, then a prime requirement would be to enhance the quality of the human resource in their midst. In other words, we need academic leaders who carry a bold and enlightened vision, somewhat of the calibre of Hardy. And it's not like we have not had such leaders in our midst. Let me cite three names from among the many outstanding vice-chancellors to grace our varsities—Maurice Gwyer at the University of Delhi, Amarnath Jha at Allahabad University and Hansa Mehta at Baroda University.

Delhi University owes so much to the striking wisdom and actions of Gwyer, who singularly helped elevate the university to a high stature. Amarnath Jha, during British times, had the boldness of vision to appoint the Nobel laureate Erwin Schrodinger to succeed the redoubtable Meghnad Saha. Schrodinger had formally accepted the offer but could not join because of the out-